Parshas Nitzavim-Vayelech

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The Lamplighter

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Parsha Insights

The Torah as G-d's Song

By Rabbi Jonathan Sacks

At the end of his life, having given the Israelites at God's behest 612 commands, Moses is instructed to give them the last; command 613:

"Now therefore write down for yourselves this song, and teach it to the people of Israel; put it in their mouths, that this song may be my witness within the people of Israel."

According to the plain sense of the verse, God is speaking to Moses and Joshua and is referring to the song in the following chapter, "Listen, O heavens, and I will speak; Hear, O earth, the words of My mouth." Oral tradition, however, gave it a different and much wider interpretation, understanding it as a command for every Jew to write – or at least take some part in writing – a Sefer Torah, a scroll of the law:

Said Rabbah: even though our ancestors have left us a scroll of the Torah, it is our religious duty to write one for ourselves, as it is said: "Now therefore write this song, and teach it to the people of Israel; put it in their mouths, that this song may be a witness for me against the people of Israel."



The logic of the interpretation seems to be, first, that the phrase "write down for yourselves" could be construed as referring to every Israelite (Ibn Ezra), not just Moses and Joshua. Secondly, the passage goes on to say: "Moses finished writing in the book the words of this law from beginning to end." The Talmud offers a third reason. The verse goes on to say: "that this song may be My witness within the people" – implying the Torah as a whole, not just the song in chapter 32.

There is something poetic about this being the last of the commands. It is as if God were saying to the Israelites: "It is not enough that you have received the Torah from Moses. You must make it new again in every generation." The covenant was not to grow old. It had to be periodically renewed.

So it is to this day, that Torah scrolls are still written as in ancient times, by hand, on parchment, using a quill – as were the Dead Sea Scrolls two thousand years ago. In a religion almost devoid of sacred objects (icons, relics), the Torah scroll is the nearest Judaism comes to endowing a physical entity with sanctity – and this is an understatement. The Torah is less like an object than a person. In its presence we stand as if it were a king. On Simchat Torah we dance with it as if it were a bride. If one is, God forbid, damaged or destroyed we bury it as if it were a human; we mourn as if we had lost a relative. Judaism is the story of a love affair between a people and a book, the Book of Books.

What though – if we take the command to refer to the whole Torah and not just one chapter – is the significance of the word "song" [shirah]: "Now therefore write down for yourselves this song"? The word shirah appears five times in this passage. It is clearly a key-word. Why? On this, two nineteenth century scholars offered striking explanations.

Netziv (R. Naftali Zvi Yehudah Berlin) interprets it to mean that the whole Torah should be read as poetry, not prose (the word shirah in Hebrew means both a song and a poem). To be sure, most of the Torah is written in prose, but it has, argues Netziv, two characteristics of poetry. First, it is allusive rather than explicit. It leaves unsaid more than is said. Secondly, like poetry, it hints at deeper reservoirs of meaning, sometimes by the use of an unusual word or sentence construction. Descriptive prose carries its meaning on the surface. The Torah, like poetry, does not.

In this brilliant insight, Netziv anticipates one of the great twentieth century essays on biblical prose, Erich Auerbach's 'Odysseus' Scar'. Auerbach contrasts the narrative style of Genesis with that of Homer. Homer uses dazzlingly detailed descriptions so that each scene is set out pictorially as if bathed in sunlight. By contrast, biblical narrative is spare and understated. In the example Auerbach cites

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What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

Candle Lighting Times

Greater Toronto Area

Light Candles	7:29 PM
Shabbos Ends	8:29 PM

Parsha in a Nutshell

Parshas Nitzavim-Vayelech

The name of the Parshah, "Nitzavim," means "Standing," and it is found in Deuteronomy 29:9. The name of the Parshah, "Vayelech," means "And [Moses] went," and it is found in Deuteronomy 31:1.

The Parshah of Nitzavim includes some of the most fundamental principles of the Jewish faith:

The unity of Israel: "You stand today, all of you, before the L-rd your G-d: your heads, your tribes, your elders, your officers, and every Israelite man; your young ones, your wives, the stranger in your gate; from your wood-hewer to your water-drawer."

The future redemption: Moses warns of the exile and desolation of the Land that will result if Israel abandons G-d's laws, but then he prophesies that in the end, "You will return to the L-rd your G-d . . . If your outcasts shall be at the ends of the heavens, from there will the L-rd your G-d gather you . . . and bring you into the Land which your fathers have possessed."

The practicality of Torah: "For the mitzvah which I command you this day, it is not beyond you, nor is it remote from you. It is not in heaven . . . It is not across the sea . . . Rather, it is very close to you, in your mouth, in your heart, that you may do it."

Freedom of choice: "I have set before you life and goodness, and death and evil: in that I command you this day to love G-d, to walk in His ways and to keep His commandments . . . Life and death I have set before you, blessing and curse. And you shall choose life."

The Parshah of Vayelech ("and he went") recounts the events of Moses' last day of earthly life. "I am one hundred and twenty years old today," he says to the people, "and I can no longer go forth and come in." He transfers the leadership to Joshua, and writes (or concludes writing) the Torah in a scroll which he entrusts to the Levites for safekeeping in the Ark of the Covenant.

The mitzvah of Hakhel ("gather") is given: every seven years, during the festival of Sukkot of the first year of the shemittah cycle, the entire people of Israel—men, women and children—should gather at the Holy Temple in Jerusalem, where the king should read to them from the Torah.

Vayelech concludes with the prediction that the people of Israel will turn away from their covenant with G-d, causing Him to hide His face from them, but also with the promise that the words of the Torah "shall not be forgotten out of the mouths of their descendants."

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– the story of the binding of Isaac – we do not know what the main characters look like, what they are feeling, what they are wearing, what landscapes they are passing through:

The decisive points of the narrative alone are emphasized, what lies between is non-existent; time and place are undefined and call for interpretation; thoughts and feelings remain unexpressed, are only suggested by the silence and the fragmentary speeches; the whole, permeated with the most unrelieved suspense and directed toward a single goal . . . remains mysterious and "fraught with background".

A completely different aspect is alluded to by R. Yechiel Michal Epstein, author of the halakhic code Arukh ha-Shulchan. Epstein points out that the rabbinic literature is full of arguments, about which the sages said: "These and those are the words of the living God." This, says Epstein, is one of the reasons the Torah is called "a song" – because a song becomes more beautiful when scored for many voices interwoven in complex harmonies.

I would suggest a third dimension. The 613th command is not simply about the Torah, but about the duty to make the Torah new in each generation. To make the Torah live anew, it is not enough to hand it on cognitively – as mere history and law. It must speak to us affectively, emotionally.

Judaism is a religion of words, and yet whenever the language of Judaism aspires to the spiritual it breaks into song, as if the words themselves sought escape from the gravitational pull of finite meanings. There is something about melody that intimates a reality beyond our grasp, what William Wordsworth called the "sense sublime / Of something far more deeply interfused / Whose dwelling is the light of setting suns / And the round ocean and the living air." Words are the language of the mind. Music is the language of the soul.

Music is central to the Judaic experience. We do not pray; we daven, meaning we sing the words we direct toward heaven. Nor do we read the Torah; instead we chant the weekly portion, each word with its own cantillation. Even rabbinical texts are never merely studied; we chant them with the particular sing-song known to all students of Talmud. Each time and text has its specific melodies. The same prayer may be sung to half-a-dozen different tunes depending on whether it is part of the morning, afternoon or evening service, and whether the day is a weekday, a Sabbath, a festival or one of the High Holy Days. There are different cantillations for biblical readings, depending on whether the text comes from the Mosaic books, the prophetic literature, or the Ketuvim, 'the writings.' Music is the map of the Jewish spirit, and each spiritual experience has its own distinctive melodic tonality.

The 613th command – to make the Torah new in every generation – symbolizes the fact that though the Torah was given once, it must be received many times, as each of us, through our study and practice, strives to recapture the pristine voice heard at Mount Sinai. That requires emotion, not just intellect. It means treating Torah not just as words read, but also as a melody sung. The Torah is God's libretto, and we, the Jewish people, are His choir, the performers of His choral symphony. And though, when Jews speak they often argue, when they sing, they sing in harmony, as the Israelites did at the Red Sea, because music is the language of the soul, and at the level of the soul Jews enter the unity of the Divine which transcends the oppositions of lower worlds. The Torah is God's song, and we collectively are its singers.

Jewish Matters

This Weeks Jewish Highlights!

Shabbat, September 5 • 23 Elul

Selichot ("supplication") prayers, recited in preparation for Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, begin this Saturday night after midnight, according to the Ashkenazic custom. (Sephardic communities begin on 1 Elul.) They are then recited each morning before the morning prayers through Elul 29, the eve of Rosh Hashanah.

Monday, September 7 • 25 Elul

The first day of Creation (3760 BCE), when G-d created the world, was the 25th of Elul. Rosh Hashanah marks the sixth day of Creation, when Adam and Eve were created and humanity entered the story of Creation. Thus, the Jewish calendar counts the years from Rosh Hashanah, while the first day of Creation falls on 25 Elul.

Food For Thought

G-d has nowhere to hide.
Other than inside you.

Your thoughts on the Lamplighter matter!
Tell us what you like and how we can improve it.

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

One Jew, Three Opinions

By Ms. Judy Waldman

My Story - with the - Rebbe



I vividly recall my father, Samuel Sydney Schwartz – Shimshon ben Menachem Mendel HaKohen – telling me in my youth, "I can trace my family back to Aharon the High Priest. That's where I come from. So you must marry Jewish. If you don't, you break the chain."

That made a strong impression on me, especially because neither of my parents was Torah observant during my formative years, and it makes the story I am about to tell even more poignant.

In 1986, I was living with my husband and children in Colorado Springs, Colorado, and my parents joined us there so that they could be closer to me and their grandchildren. A year later, Rabbi Mendy Teitelbaum came to the area as the Chabad emissary, and my father developed a close relationship with him. Rabbi Teitelbaum knew that if he was short a man for the minyan, or if he needed help with a particular mitzvah, he could always count on my father.

When my father was subsequently diagnosed with cancer, of course, he had to let Rabbi Teitelbaum know he would not be available: "I want you to know that I'll be having surgery so I won't be able to join you for prayer services for a while. It looks like I'll be out of commission for months, so don't count on me."

Naturally, Rabbi Teitelbaum asked, "What kind of surgery?"

"For lung cancer," my father replied. "I've been a smoker my whole life and this is the price I now have to pay. They are going to remove my left lung."

"I'm so sorry to hear that. Can I tell this to the Rebbe?"

At that time, my father had no special connection to the Rebbe, so he merely said, "Sure, if you want to tell your rabbi, tell your rabbi; it's okay with me."

Rabbi Teitelbaum picked up the phone to call New York and came back to my father with: "The Rebbe says you should get a second opinion."

"Not a bad idea," my father responded, and he followed through. But the second opinion was no different from the first: "You've got cancer in your left lung and you should have it removed immediately."

When my father related this to Rabbi Teitelbaum, Rabbi Teitelbaum again called New York and came back to my father with: "Get a third opinion and listen to whatever that doctor says."

This was a little hard for my father to accept, largely because there were no more surgeons specializing in pulmonology in Colorado Springs, so he'd have to go far out of town. But Rabbi Teitelbaum convinced him that it would not be wise to disregard the Rebbe's advice, and my father ended up making an appointment at a hospital in Denver – what was then called National Jewish Health Center for Immunology and Respiratory Medicine. They had specialized for many decades in tuberculosis and asthma, and thus it was an appropriate place for treatment of my father's lung issue.

Oddly, the doctor there wanted to know where my father was born. He was surprised to hear the response: Philadelphia. Why? Because his tests showed what appeared to be a lung fungus common to people in the South.

But then my father clarified, "My parents moved to Memphis when I was six years old, and I lived in Memphis for thirty-five years!"

"Well, that explains it. And I am happy to tell you that you don't have lung cancer. You've got histoplasmosis. It's a fungus that comes from birds or bats and it's in the soil in the South. You do need to quit smoking, but you don't need surgery."

You can imagine the relief our whole family felt, and how grateful we were to the Rebbe for insisting on a third opinion.

About a year later, I moved with my family to Miami Beach, Florida, and my parents opted to return to Cherry Hill, New Jersey, where they had lived previously. After seven years there, my father was again diagnosed with lung cancer – this time in his right lung – and surgery was again recommended.

Unfortunately, this cancer was for real, and he did have his right lung removed. But none of us failed to appreciate that had his left lung been erroneously removed years earlier, he would not be able to have this life-saving surgery now. Obviously, a person can't have both lungs removed. So had the Rebbe not advised as he did, my father would not have had this option for treatment. His life would have ended with a long painful death from terminal cancer.

As it happened, he was able to have the surgery, which was successful. He lived another five years during which he saw another grandchild born to him, and his older grandchildren marry. None of this would have been possible without the Rebbe's intercession.

Now, there is an addendum to this story.

After my father's second lung cancer diagnosis, my parents decided to move to Palm Beach, Florida, where they became close to Rabbi Moshe Scheiner, who led the local synagogue. Years later, after my father passed away, my mother went to Rabbi Scheiner and said, "I want to keep Shabbat now."

Rabbi Scheiner informed her that if she wanted to keep Shabbat properly, she couldn't drive to prayer services. He convinced her to move to Delray Beach, where my sister lived, and where she would be within walking distance of a synagogue.

And so it was that through this chain of events my mother became Shomer Shabbat at age seventy-two and ended up keeping Shabbat for the next twenty years.

One beautiful story on top of another.

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Ms. Judy Waldman, a yacht broker, has been living in South Florida for the past thirty-six years. She was interviewed in June 2026.

What's Riskier: Shul or a Road Trip?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

Question:

I had planned to spend the High Holidays in Israel this year, but cancelled the trip because of the security situation. Now that I'm staying in Australia, some friends have suggested that we take a road trip over the holiday period instead. The alternative is attending Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur services here. I usually go, but this year I'm nervous about that too. Jewish institutions have become potential targets, and seeing security guards and police outside the synagogue doesn't reassure me. It reminds me that there is something to be afraid of.

Part of me thinks I should stop putting myself in situations of danger, take the road trip and forget about the whole thing this year. But another part of me wonders whether I'm allowing fear to push me away from something important.

Help me think clearly about this. Am I being sensibly cautious, or am I letting fear make my decisions for me?

Response:

This isn't only a question about thinking. It's about feeling.

Because if this were purely rational, your road trip could be the riskiest activity of all. Let's look at the statistics.

Since the establishment of the State of Israel, more than seven times as many people have been killed on Israel's roads as civilians have been killed by terrorism.

And here's another surprising stat: Australia's per-capita road-death rate has been higher than Israel's in every year for the past decade. And yet an Aussie road trip feels perfectly safe, while an Israel trip feels dangerous.

This is human nature. We ignore the dangers we are used to, while becoming fearful of the dangers that grab our attention. We know road accidents happen. But terrorism feels different. It is deliberate, dramatic and confronting. Facts may put the danger in perspective, but they don't make the fear go away.

For that, we don't need stats, we need security.

The Hebrew word for security is bitachon. It is also the word for trust in G-d. That is not a coincidence. We cannot eliminate every possible danger. Our sense of security comes from knowing that our lives are in G-d's hands.

Bitachon does not mean being irresponsible. We wear seatbelts, look both ways before crossing the road, and avoid unnecessary danger. Our synagogues have trained security guards, cameras, police support, and sensible procedures. These safety measures are not a reason to stay away. They are there to make it safer for you to come. They protect us on the outside. Bitachon gives us security on the inside.

You cancelled one journey because of fear. Don't allow fear to cancel the journey your soul needs to make. Not a road trip. A walk to shul.

Living Moshiach

"You will return unto G-d... and G-d, your G-d, will bring back your captivity." (Nitzavim 30:2-3)

Rashi comments: The return of the captivity will be "as though G-d Himself seizes with His hands every single individual from his place, as it is said, 'you will be gathered up one by one, O Children of Israel'" (Isaiah 27:12).

As the redemption will be brought about by teshuvah-repentance ("you will return unto G-d"), it follows that just as the redemption itself will be for "every single individual... one by one," so, too, every single one shall return unto G-d.

Thus it is stated explicitly in the next verse of Isaiah's prophecy: "On that day, a great shofar will be blown, and those who are lost in the land of Assyria and those who are cast away in the land of Egypt shall come, and they will bow down before G-d on the holy mountain in Jerusalem" (Isaiah 27:13). In other words, even those who are so deeply immersed in the galut that they became "lost" and "cast away," they, too, will be awakened by teshuvah.

Mitzvah Minute

Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish New Year, is the beginning and centerpiece of the High Holy Days. It is a time of reflection, prayer, and celebration as we renew our relationship with G-d and crown Him King of the universe.

The holiday is marked by special prayers, festive meals, and the sounding of the shofar, whose blasts serve as a call to return to G-d and prepare for the year ahead.

Rosh Hashanah 2026: Begins before sundown on Friday, September 11, and ends after nightfall on Sunday, September 13.

The Lamplighter

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This publication contains words from sacred literature. Please treat it with respect and do not deface or discard.

The Lamplighter is inspired by the works of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

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